



WHAT DID YOU DO DURING THE UPRISING?

ASHES AND DIAMONDS / 1958

IN CONTEXT

GENRE
War drama

DIRECTOR
Andrzej Wajda

WRITERS
Andrzej Wajda, Jerzy Andrzejewski (screenplay); Jerzy Andrzejewski (novel)

STARS
Zbigniew Cybulski, Wacław Zastrzeżynski, Adam Pawlikowski, Bogumil Kobiela

BEFORE
1955 Wajda's directorial debut, *A Generation*, is the story of Stach, a wayward teen living in Nazi-occupied Warsaw, Poland, during World War II.

AFTER
1969 After the death of actor Zbigniew Cybulski in a train wreck, Wajda channeled his grief into his next, highly personal work, *Everything for Sale*, a movie within a movie.



The title of Andrzej Wajda's war movie comes from a line of romantic poetry by 19th-century Polish poet Cyprian Norwid: "Will there remain among the ashes a star-like diamond, the dawn of eternal victory?" It is this uncertainty that characterizes all of Wajda's movies, most of which recreate the horror and heartbreak of Poland's recent history—from its occupation by the Nazis during World War II to the Stalinist regime that lasted until 1989—in order to make sense of it. They sift through the wreckage of ordinary people's lives, looking for glimmers of hope.

Maciek (Zbigniew Cybulski) is plunged into self doubt when he meets Krystyna (Ewa Krzyżewska). His crisis is played out over a single night—May 8, 1945, the last day of war, when Poland, too, is deeply divided.

Wajda emerged as a world-class filmmaker during the renaissance of Polish cinema in the 1950s. He made three movies dealing with the war. *A Generation* (1955) followed a group of men and women fighting in Nazi-occupied Poland. This was followed by *Kanal* (1957), which chronicles the tragic events of the 1944 Warsaw Uprising, in which